



Priced with Confidence, Not Consensus

A Pre/Post Survey of Garage-Sale Sellers and the Group Chat That Weighs In

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The problem

Neighbourhood garage-sale sellers routinely post an item’s price to the street group chat before the folding tables go out. Little is known about whether the replies that follow change how sure a seller feels about the number, or only whether a reply landing at all does.

Research questions

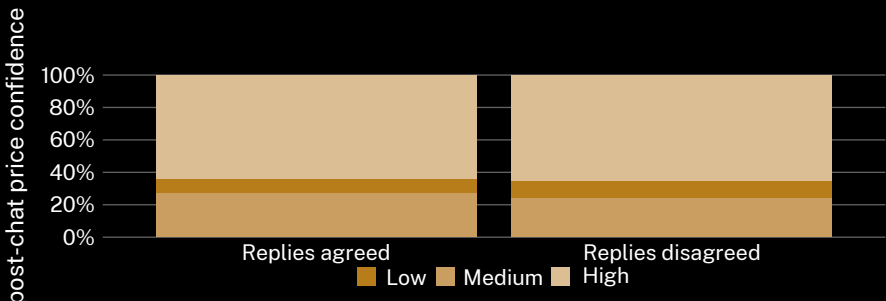
- Rate sellers’ price confidence immediately before and after the street chat responds
- Compare confidence movement between chats that converge on a figure and chats that scatter
- Track confidence against how close the eventual sale landed to the posted price

Study design

- n = 118 sellers · 9 street and apartment-block chats · one spring selling season
- Confidence self-rated 1–7, pre/post; each chat’s replies logged and scored for spread
- Confidence change regressed on reply spread and sale-to-ask ratio; thresholds pre-registered

Findings

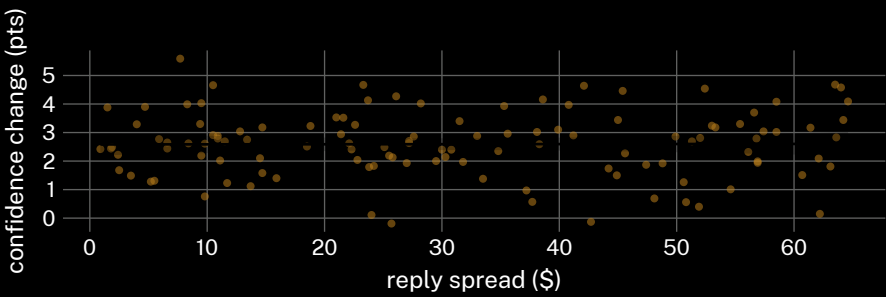
Confidence climbs sharply once the chat responds, whether or not the replies agree. The rise tracks neither reply spread nor how close the eventual sale price landed to the posted figure.



Sellers reporting high price confidence (self-rated $\geq 6/7$) after the chat responds: 64% when replies agreed within \$5, 65% when replies spanned \$40 or more — against 21% before any reply landed (n = 118 sellers, nine street chats, one spring selling season).

Implications

A chat weighing in functions less as a corrective signal than as a ritual of having asked. Sellers whose price sat furthest above the chat’s own median were, if anything, the most confident of the lot. The confidence bump also shows no sign of fading before the tables go out — sellers surveyed again at the sale itself report the same rating they gave the chat an hour earlier. Next: extend the design to marketplace-app comment threads, where the same reassurance-without-correction pattern may recur.



Confidence change (post-chat minus pre-chat rating) against reply spread, one point per seller: a near-flat fitted line (slope ≈ 0.00 pts per \$10 of spread, $r = 0.06$, $n = 118$) — the chat’s agreement or disagreement carries no signal either way.

Selected references

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We thank the sellers and administrators of the nine participating street and block chats. Confidence ratings, reply counts, and sale prices retained; message text and participant identities were not.